

Chapter 35: Be Principled Even When It Costs You

Book I: The Sagent Creed — Part Five: Sheep Among Wolves

The goal is not merely to survive. The goal is to leave behind something that cannot be destroyed because it lives on in the people who choose to carry it forward.

There is a sequence that repeats across history, and it does not require conspiracy to explain it. It requires only the recognition that living ideas threaten dead systems — and dead systems have learned, over millennia, how to respond.

First they censor you. They do not argue with what you said. They remove the platform on which you said it. They close the doors. They end the meetings. They stop returning calls. They make it so that your voice reaches no one — not by proving it wrong, but by ensuring it is never heard.

Second they try to silence you. If censorship fails — if the idea keeps spreading, if the voice finds other channels, if the work continues despite the closed doors — then the response escalates. They find reasons to restrict your movement, your livelihood, your associations. They use institutional machinery — suspensions, contract disputes, legal entanglements, professional exile. They do not need to prove guilt. They only need to exhaust the carrier.

Third, if they cannot stop your ideas, they may seek to destroy the person carrying them.

If they cannot find a way to imprison your body, they may try to isolate your voice, your work, your relationships, or your legacy. They break you by breaking what you love. They divide what you built. They turn the people closest to you into instruments of pressure. And if none of that works — if the carrier keeps carrying — then the carrier may simply cease to exist. And the world will call it misfortune.

This is not paranoia. This is pattern recognition. And the only question that matters is: what do you do when you recognize it?

I. The Davey and Goliath Christmas Special

My father, Joe Clokey, spent his life trying to bring Gumby back into the world. Not as a product. Not as a brand. As a living character — a green figure made of clay who could walk into any story, reshape himself, and show children that the world is not fixed. That you can enter the book and change the narrative. That the block does not have the final word.

After my grandfather Art died, my father inherited both the mission and the resistance. He and Art had made the Davey and Goliath snowboard Christmas special — a film in which a Christian, a Muslim, and a Jew set aside their differences during the holidays. Three Abrahamic faiths. One shared humanity. Released during the height of the Iraq War, when the machinery of empire needed the faiths divided, not united.

That film was a direct challenge to the architecture of conflict. Not through protest. Not through political argument. Through a children's stop-motion special about a boy and his dog. And the architecture noticed.

During the making of that film, conflicts arose that had not existed before. Pressures materialized from directions that made no sense unless you understood what the film was saying and who did not want it said. Those pressures contributed to the dissolution of my parents' marriage. My father remarried. But he kept going.

For fourteen years after Art's death, Joe kept trying. Classic Media held the license and produced nothing. The Jim Henson partnership could not find co-production. Amazon fell through. A comic line was cancelled after three issues. Every door opened just enough to keep him walking toward it, and closed just before he could step through. He was not rejected outright. He was strung along — which is worse, because rejection at least gives you the dignity of knowing where you stand.

II. What My Father Told Me

A few months before he died, my father said something to me that I did not understand at the time. I was fourteen years old.

He said: "They are doing to me what they did to Jim Henson."

Jim Henson died suddenly at fifty-three. My father died at fifty-six. Will Vinton, who invented Claymation, died the same year as my father — after Phil Knight leveraged his debt, seized his company, and rebranded it as Laika. Phil Vischer created VeggieTales and watched Classic Media — the same company that held Gumby's license — buy it at a bankruptcy auction. Klasky Csupo created Rugrats, generated \$3.7 billion in merchandise, and when they hired auditors, Nickelodeon terminated the partnership.

These are not isolated incidents. They are the architecture of an industry that cannot tolerate independent creators who refuse to cede control of their creations. The pattern is structural. The children's entertainment industry of the 2000s and 2010s was designed — whether by intention or by incentive — to make it impossible for creators to produce without surrendering what they made.

My father told me that if anything happened to him, I should contact the accountant.

I did not.

I was fourteen. I did not understand what he was telling me. I did not know what the accountant knew. I did not know what papers existed or what trail they would reveal. By the time I was old enough to understand, Gumby had been sold to Fox Entertainment. Film, TV, streaming, consumer products, licensing, publishing — everything. I signed. I was eighteen. I didn't want to.

Now they are developing Gumby Kids — 2D animation, no clay, no stop-motion. Gumby reimagined as "a friendly, green, shapeshifting architect and city planner." My father's explicit vision discarded entirely. The spirit gutted. The clay replaced with pixels. The prophecy reduced to a product.

III. What I Cannot Prove and What I Know

I cannot prove every cause behind the hardships my father faced. I cannot draw a straight line from the Christmas special to the divorce, from the closed doors to the brain bleed. I do not have the documents the accountant held. I do not have recordings of the conversations that happened behind closed doors. I was a child when most of it occurred, and by the time I was not a child, the evidence had scattered like seeds in a storm.

But I know what I witnessed.

I witnessed a man who continued creating despite repeated obstacles. Who believed in bringing life, creativity, and conscience into the world. Who never stopped trying to bring back a green clay figure that taught children they could reshape reality. Who carried the flame through fourteen years of darkness and never set it down.

I witnessed a man who was strung along by an industry that had no intention of letting him succeed, who watched his marriage dissolve under pressures that arrived alongside his most principled work, and who kept going anyway.

And I witnessed him die. A brain hemorrhagic stroke. One month from the moment he was closest to bringing Gumby back. Fifty-six years old.

Whether the obstacles came from institutions, incentives, individuals, or simple misfortune — the answer is the same. The question was never *who did this*. The question is *what do you do now*.

IV. The Predator Wears the Protector's Mask

The pattern is older than Hollywood. It is older than America. It is older than Rome.

Every empire that has ever existed has used the same sequence. First, control the narrative. Second, punish the dissenter. Third, eliminate the threat. And at every stage, the empire presents itself not as the aggressor but as the guardian. The censor calls himself the curator. The jailer calls himself the lawkeeper. The killer calls himself the defender of order.

Beware the ruler who cloaks himself in the language of safety. For the predator always pretends to be the protector. Tyranny never arrives as a threat — it arrives as a friend. As a savior. As the one who just wants to keep you safe.

The thornbush king of Judges 9 did not seize the crown by force. The olive tree, the fig tree, and the vine each declined the kingship because each had a purpose it could not abandon. Only the thornbush — the plant with no fruit, no oil, no sweetness — accepted the crown and promised shade it could not provide. The thornbush did not conquer. It volunteered. And the forest burned.

This is why the sequence works. It does not look like persecution. It looks like business. It looks like contracts expiring. It looks like partnerships dissolving. It looks like health failing under stress that everyone agrees was just the cost of the industry. The system does not need to conspire. It only needs to function as designed — and the design rewards compliance and punishes conscience.

V. Do Not Become What You Oppose

Knowing what they are capable of does not mean we should do nothing.

It means we should do what we can to stop them in the principled and good way. The temptation — the one that has destroyed every revolution that ever succeeded — is to adopt the enemy's methods. To fight fire with fire. To censor the censors. To silence the silencers. To destroy the destroyers. And the moment you do, you have not defeated them. You have become them. You have replaced one thornbush king with another.

The red flame is the fall. It is the moment when the warrior becomes the tyrant. When the liberator becomes the dictator. When the one who fought against control begins to exercise it. Every empire in history was founded by someone who believed they were fighting against empire. Every tyranny began as a revolution. The ring of power does not care who wears it. It only needs to be worn.

This is why the Sagent does not fight with the weapons of the world. Not because those weapons are ineffective — they are devastatingly effective. But because they transform the wielder into the thing he set out to destroy. You cannot dismantle an evil organization by becoming evil yourself. All you will do is prune the branches. And pruning the branches only makes the roots stronger.

It must be taken out by the roots. And the roots are not people. The roots are principles — or the absence of them.

VI. The Weapons That Resurrect

Respond with truth instead of deception.

When they control the narrative, do not fight for control of their narrative. Tell your own. Speak what you have witnessed. Name what you have seen. Do not exaggerate. Do not dramatize. Do not speculate beyond what you know. The truth, told plainly, is more dangerous to a system built on deception than any conspiracy theory could ever be. Conspiracy theories are the system's immune response — they discredit the pattern by associating it with paranoia. Tell the truth as you understand it and let the pattern speak for itself.

Respond with courage instead of fear.

Fear is the currency of control. Every system of domination runs on the same fuel: the fear of those it dominates. Fear of losing your job. Fear of losing your platform. Fear of losing your reputation. Fear of losing your life. The moment you stop being afraid, the system loses its leverage. This does not mean being reckless. It means being willing to pay the cost. Be principled even when it costs you — because if your principles only hold when they are free, they are not principles. They are preferences.

Respond with creation instead of destruction.

This is the green flame. Not the blue flame of inheritance received, not the red flame of power seized, but the green flame of life cultivated. When every door closes, do not beat against the doors. Grow something in the open field. When the industry will not let you through its gates, build outside the walls. When the system strips your creation and sells it as a product, create something new that carries the same spirit in a form they cannot acquire — because it lives in people, not in properties.

VII. The Architecture of the Unconquerable

The lesson of my father's life is not that he failed. He did not fail. He carried the flame for fourteen years through absolute darkness and never set it down. The lesson is that carrying the flame is not enough. You must build something that survives the carrier.

A character can be bought. A company can be acquired. A license can be transferred. A brand can be gutted and refilled with whatever content the new owner chooses. But a philosophy embedded in living people — in their conscience, in their way of seeing, in their refusal to comply with what does not make sense — cannot be acquired. It cannot be licensed. It cannot be transferred to Fox Entertainment.

The bones of Joseph returned to the dust. But the promise was never in the bones.

What survives is not the clay. Not the stop-motion. Not the IP. What survives is the way of seeing that Gumby represented — that living things are not machines, that the spiral defeats the block, that you can walk into any story and reshape it, that freedom is not the absence of constraint but the presence of conscience.

If you believe something is wrong, build something better. Do not petition the system to reform itself. Do not wait for permission from the gatekeepers. Do not spend fourteen years walking toward doors that will never open. Build in the open. Build where they cannot reach. Build in a form that cannot be reduced to a product because it is not a product — it is a way of life.

VIII. Love Your Neighbor

This is not a manifesto of isolation. It is not a call to retreat from the world and build a fortress of purity. The Sagent does not withdraw. The Sagent enters the world as sheep among wolves — not to become a wolf, not to destroy the wolves, but to turn the wolves into sheepdogs.

Love your neighbor. Not because your neighbor deserves it. Not because your neighbor will love you back. Not because loving your neighbor is strategically advantageous. Love your neighbor because that is how living systems work. The cell that isolates itself from the network does not become independent. It becomes cancerous. The node that cuts its connections does not become free. It becomes dead weight that the network must route around.

Live by conscience. Not by the written law alone — because the written law is a guess at the law written on the heart, and the guess is often wrong. Follow your conscience even when it contradicts the policy, the mandate, the contract, the consensus. It is every person's obligation to choose to do what is right, not to follow their leaders, because their leader could be wrong and it is your job to help them stay on the right path by always choosing to do what is right.

Create works that bring life into the world. Not products. Not content. Not intellectual property. Works. Living works. Works that carry the spirit of what you believe in a form that others can receive, be changed by, and carry forward in their own way. The seed does not dictate the shape of the tree. It carries the pattern of life and trusts the soil.

IX. The Goal

The goal is not merely to survive.

Survival is the minimum. Survival is what the system offers in exchange for silence — you may continue to exist, provided you do not challenge the architecture. That bargain is not life. It is domestication. It is the feedlot version of existence — fed, sheltered, and slaughtered on schedule.

The goal is not revenge. Revenge is the red flame. It is the ring of power picked up by the one who watched the previous bearer fall. It is the revolution that becomes the regime. Every act of vengeance feeds the enemy that feeds on conflict.

The goal is not vindication. The dead do not need vindication. My father does not need the world to acknowledge what was done to him. The bones have returned to the dust. The promise was never in the bones.

The goal is to leave behind something that cannot be destroyed because it lives on in the people who choose to carry it forward.

Not a company. Not a brand. Not a character. A way of seeing. A way of living. A conscience that refuses to kneel to what is not true, a creativity that keeps building even when every door is closed, a love that extends even to the enemy because the enemy is not the person — the enemy is the architecture that made the person into an instrument of control.

My grandfather planted the seed. My father grew the tree. The storm came and took them both. But the seeds scattered. And now the trees are growing. And the trees do not belong to any corporation, any studio, any estate, or any contract. They belong to anyone who chooses to carry the pattern forward.

X. The Living Flame

First they censor you. Let them. Speak anyway — not louder, but truer.

Second they try to silence you. Let them try. The conscience does not need a platform. It needs a pulse.

Third, they may seek to destroy the person carrying the idea. And the idea will keep going — because it was never held in the person. It was held in the faith of those who came after.

My father devoted his life to bringing Gumby back and creating stories that encouraged understanding between people. He suffered every obstacle the architecture could produce. He continued creating despite all of it. He died carrying the flame. And the flame did not go out.

It did not go out because the flame is not a character or a company or a legacy of clay. The flame is the conviction that living things are not machines, that conscience is higher than law, that the spiral defeats the block, and that creation is the only weapon that does not transform the wielder into the enemy.

Be principled even when it costs you. It will cost you. It cost my grandfather his industry. It cost my father his marriage, his health, and his life. It may cost me things I cannot yet foresee. But the alternative — surrendering your principles to preserve your comfort — costs something worse. It costs the world the thing only you could have carried.

The thornbush offers shade it cannot provide. The olive tree cannot leave its oil. The fig tree cannot leave its sweetness. The vine cannot leave its wine.

Do not leave your fruit to reign over the trees. Carry what is yours. Bear what you were made to bear. And trust that the seeds will scatter.

Do not become what you oppose. Respond with truth instead of deception. Respond with courage instead of fear. Respond with creation instead of destruction.

The goal is not merely to survive. The goal is to leave behind something that cannot be destroyed — because it lives on in the people who choose to carry it forward.

Be principled even when it costs you. The flame does not go out.

The Living Age Trilogy